

Genuinely how the fuck does AI waste water if water can be reused infinitely?

Posted by u/red-fox-972x • 0 points • 17 comments

How does anything waste water if water is basically an infinite recourse because of how much there is and the fact that it can be infinitely reused?

Comments

u/PixelPrivateer • 0 points • 2026-02-09 21:20 UTC

I have a tinfoil hat theory on this- People won't agree and fair enough but I think the water waste issue is bs-- not that I think it's a 'lie' but it will end up like the paper straws thing: We get to deal with crumpled soggy paper while Taylor Swift flies to France for a sundae.

In other words: AI will be greatly restricted in civilian use but corporations will still get to use it with abandon to compete with nations that just don't care either way on environmental impact since to *not* use it will be a death sentence to any global competitor. The environment will be used as the bludgeon to justify it happening and then will be discarded immediately. Having it be limited to corporate use in tandem makes regulation and control of content much easier- no more threat to Hollywood, no more combing through thousands of legal documents to find out where a politician is full of shit, and also means no more deep fake porn of celebrities (what I'm getting at is they have an ocean of reasons to do this, dubious or otherwise, whether we like it or not)

u/sugarw0000kie • 3 points • 2026-02-09 21:16 UTC

everyone pointing out finite in single location so I'll point out the obvious, oceans man. Salt is pretty obviously highly corrosive so you need to take the salt out far as I know

Two main ways to do it, boil it, which needs a ton of energy obviously, or reverse osmosis, which is still expensive to setup and maintain. Assuming you don't need to worry about transporting the water long distances, your cheaper option is to suck up the groundwater and tell the host town to fuck off and find their own water

u/prunejuice • 2 points • 2026-02-09 21:13 UTC

Water isn't being destroyed by AI - instead what people mean by wasted is that clean, drinkable freshwater is used in a way that makes it unavailable or unusable for humans.

In the case of AI data centers (or power plants, or factories...), large amounts of potable water are used for cooling. After that, the water may be evaporated, re-entering the water cycle as water vapor (which isn't directly usable by people until it eventually falls as rain), or, more likely, discharged as contaminated unpotable water, meaning it requires energy-intensive treatment before it can be safely reused.

u/prunejuice • 2 points • 2026-02-09 21:15 UTC

Replying to my own post to mention that Hank Green does a fantastic video all about this - it's far more nuanced than most people grasp and is worth the watch if you're looking for more information!

https://youtu.be/H_c6MWk7PQc?si=UvDyOXNbE33m3v_U

u/Interesting_Play_578 • 1 points • 2026-02-09 21:13 UTC

Here are three threads on this subject from the last week alone, maybe those can help you

[https://www.reddit.com/r/NoStupidQuestions/comments/1qvutby/how_does_ai_waste_water/]
(https://www.reddit.com/r/NoStupidQuestions/comments/1qvutby/how_does_ai_waste_water/)

[https://www.reddit.com/r/NoStupidQuestions/comments/1qvs0qd/where_does_the_water_ai_uses_go/]
(https://www.reddit.com/r/NoStupidQuestions/comments/1qvs0qd/where_does_the_water_ai_uses_go/)

[https://www.reddit.com/r/NoStupidQuestions/comments/1qqg5nm/how_do_ai_data_centers_use_and_pollute_water/]
(https://www.reddit.com/r/NoStupidQuestions/comments/1qqg5nm/how_do_ai_data_centers_use_and_pollute_water/)

u/Netraad • 2 points • 2026-02-09 21:12 UTC

The cooling process the water performs in the data center transfers heat to the water.

The *cheapest* way to dissipate that heat and make the water compatible with the next cycle is evaporative cooling.

This means they 'lose' some of the water pool to the air. They then make that shortage up from the local source. Repeat this cycle 24x7x365 and they can quickly tax local resources.

u/HumungreousNobolatis • 1 points • 2026-02-09 21:10 UTC

Water is going round and round, sure. But fresh, *cold* water, is not.

Once the water has been heated (by the data centre), it is no longer useful for cooling, so get drained off somewhere.

u/bangbangracer • 2 points • 2026-02-09 21:07 UTC

We all know the water cycle. The problem is that it is slow and doesn't put water back where it was.

Water cooled data centers pull water from the reservoir faster than treatment plants and the water cycle can put more water back into the reservoir.

u/heyheyheytheree • 3 points • 2026-02-09 21:06 UTC

Basically when water is the coolant, its cheaper to dump the hot water and pull in fresh water than to cool it down and reuse it

u/fossSellsKeys • 5 points • 2026-02-09 21:06 UTC

Water is very much an infinite resource. But, fresh, clean, and drinkable water is not. It can be hard to find and expensive to produce. AI data centers turn lots of potable water into unusable water for human consumption, that's the waste people are talking about. It can of course be reclaimed, but only at great expense. Just like all water issues, it's more of a cost issue than a water issue. There's plenty of water on earth, the trick is having it available at a low cost when and where you need it.

u/shootYrTv • 5 points • 2026-02-09 21:06 UTC

Water is effectively a finite resource in places where it does not rain. Like, for example, the deserts of California and Nevada, where tons of these data centers are being built. Without precipitation to refill the water tables, water can be depleted.

Just ask a Californian who's been barred from washing their car to conserve water.

u/LaughingAtYourLogic • 1 points • 2026-02-09 21:05 UTC

It evaporates

u/KronusIV • 8 points • 2026-02-09 21:05 UTC

The total water in the world is huge. The water feeding my town comes from a reservoir, and that's very finite. The water that data center uses isn't going back to the reservoir afterwards, it's off into the atmosphere or going down stream. As far as the town is concerned all that water is gone, and if they're not getting enough rain to make up for it then they're in big trouble.

u/aaronite • 31 points • 2026-02-09 21:05 UTC

Fresh water in a specific location is not remotely infinite. We use fresh water faster than it can be replenished.

It's basically the same concept as asking why the homeless guy on the corner isn't rich if there's trillions of dollars in the world: it's because it's concentrated all in the places he can't get at.

u/HollowBlades • 1 points • 2026-02-09 21:36 UTC

To add onto this, freshwater is very limited. Only about 2.5% of all the water on earth is freshwater. And of that 2.5% only about 21% is liquid - lakes, rivers, groundwater, etc. The rest is tied up in permafrost and glaciers. That works about to just 0.525% of all the water on Earth being fresh, useable water. Water that's being rapidly used for AI data centers.

u/proviquea • 6 points • 2026-02-09 21:09 UTC

This is the most elegant way of saying "use your brain, not just the first Google result"

u/Practical_Newt8845 • 10 points • 2026-02-09 21:04 UTC

the problem isn't that water disappears forever, it's that cleaning and processing it back to usable quality takes energy and infrastructure that many places don't have enough of. when data centers use millions of gallons for cooling, that water gets heated up and contaminated so it needs treatment before going back into the system

plus water isn't evenly distributed - using tons of it in already dry areas means less available locally even if theoretically it'll cycle back eventually